

Excessive or Frequent Urination

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Most people urinate about 4 to 6 times a day, mostly in the daytime. Normally, adults pass between 3 cups (700 milliliters) and 3 quarts (3 liters) of urine a day. Excessive urination can refer to

- An increased volume of urine (polyuria)
- A normal volume of urine with the need to go more often (urinary frequency)
- Both

Urinary frequency may be accompanied by a sensation of an urgent need to urinate ([urinary urgency](#)). Many people particularly notice polyuria because they have to get up to urinate during the night (nocturia). Nocturia also can occur if people drink too much fluid too close to bedtime, even if they drink no more than normal overall.

(See [Overview of Urinary Tract Symptoms](#).)

Causes of Excessive or Frequent Urination

Some of the causes of increased urine volume differ from those of too-frequent urination. However, because many people who produce excessive amounts of urine also need to urinate frequently, these 2 symptoms are often considered together.

The **most common causes of urinary frequency** are

- [Bladder infections](#) (the most common cause in women and children)
- [Urinary incontinence](#)
- Noncancerous enlargement of the prostate gland ([benign prostatic hyperplasia](#)—the most common cause in men over 50)

- [Stones in the urinary tract](#)

The **most common causes of polyuria** in both adults and children are

- Uncontrolled [diabetes mellitus](#) (most common)
- Drinking too much fluid (polydipsia)
- [Arginine vasopressin deficiency](#)
- [Arginine vasopressin resistance](#)
- Taking diuretic drugs or substances (which increase the excretion of urine), such as alcohol or [caffeine](#)

Antidiuretic hormone helps the kidneys reabsorb fluid. If too little antidiuretic hormone is produced (a condition called [arginine vasopressin deficiency](#)) or if the kidneys are unable to properly respond to it ([arginine vasopressin resistance](#)), the person urinates excessively.

People with certain kidney disorders (such as interstitial nephritis or kidney damage resulting from [sickle cell anemia](#)) may also urinate excessively because these disorders also decrease the amount of fluid reabsorbed by the kidneys.

Rarely, urinary frequency is caused by [spinal cord injury or disorder](#).

Evaluation of Excessive or Frequent Urination

Many people are embarrassed to discuss problems related to urination with their doctor. But because some disorders that cause excessive urination are quite serious, people who urinate excessively should be evaluated by a doctor. The following information can help people know when to see a doctor and what to expect during the evaluation.

Warning signs

In people with excessive urination, certain symptoms and characteristics are cause for concern. They include

- Weakness of the legs
- Fever and back pain
- Abrupt onset or onset during the first few years of life
- Night sweats, cough, and weight loss, especially in a person who has an extensive smoking history
- A mental health condition

When to see a doctor

People who have leg weakness should go to the hospital immediately because they may have a spinal cord disorder. People who have fever and back pain should see a doctor within a day because they may have a [kidney infection](#). People who have other warning signs should see a doctor within 1 or 2 days. People without warning signs should schedule an appointment as soon as is convenient, usually within a few days to a week, although waiting longer is usually safe if symptoms have been developing over weeks or longer and are mild.

What the doctor does

Doctors first ask questions about the person's symptoms and medical history and then do a physical examination. What they find during the history and physical examination often suggests a cause of excessive urination and the tests that may need to be done (see table [Some Causes and Features of Excessive Urination](#))

Doctors ask about

- Amounts of fluid drunk and urinated to determine whether the problem is related to urinary frequency or to polyuria
- How long symptoms have been present
- Whether any other urination problems are present
- Whether the person is taking diuretics (medications and other substances that increase urine production), including beverages that contain [caffeine](#)

Some obvious findings may give clues to the cause of frequent urination. Pain or burning during urination, fever, and back or side pain may indicate an infection. In a person who drinks large amounts of beverages that contain [caffeine](#) or who has just started treatment with a diuretic, the diuretic substance is a likely cause. A man who has other problems with urination, such as difficulty starting urination, a weak urine stream, and dribbling at the end of urination, may have a prostate disorder.

Some obvious findings may also give clues to the cause of polyuria. For example, polyuria that starts during the first few years of life is likely caused by an inherited disorder such as [arginine vasopressin deficiency](#) or [arginine vasopressin resistance](#) or [type 1 diabetes mellitus](#).

In women, the physical examination usually includes a pelvic examination and the taking of samples of cervical and vaginal fluid to check for sexually transmitted infections. In men, the penis is examined for presence of a discharge, and doctors do a digital rectal examination to examine the prostate.



Some Causes and Features of Excessive Urination

Cause	Common Features*	Tests
Disorders that cause primarily frequent urination		
<u>Cystitis</u> (bladder infection)	Usually in women and girls A frequent and urgent need to urinate Burning or pain during urination Sometimes fever and pain in the lower back or side Sometimes blood in the urine or foul-smelling urine	<u>Urinalysis</u> and <u>urine culture</u>
Pregnancy	Typically during the last several months of pregnancy	A doctor's examination Sometimes urinalysis (to look for a <u>urinary tract infection</u>)
 <u>Prostate enlargement</u> (benign or cancerous)	Mainly in men over 50 Slowly worsening urinary symptoms, such as difficulty starting urination, a weak urine stream, dribbling at the end of urination, and a sensation of incomplete urination Often detected during a digital rectal examination	Blood tests to measure the PSA level If the PSA level is elevated, <u>biopsy of the prostate</u> Sometimes ultrasonography